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Terry Gibbs

Terry Gibbs was born Julius Gubenko on October 13, 1924 in New York City. He has shared the bandstand and recording studio with a long list of major jazz artists including Buddy Rich, Benny Goodman and Mel Torme. Terry's vibraphone, drumming and band leader skills have been a significant part of jazz in America for over sixty years.

Terry was interviewed in New York City on January 12, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in New York City. I'm pleased to have the opportunity to speak with Terry Gibbs here, who just described himself as a hero of New York.

TG: I'm a hero. I grew up in New York and it's very fortunate, I really did well in New York. I was accepted royally. I was the house band leader at Birdland in my younger days. There would always be Count Basie, Sarah Vaughan, Terry Gibbs, Duke Ellington, Dinah Washington, Terry Gibbs. But I was there six months a year, and I'd be on the road the other six months. But I was always accepted and it was great. I got a chance to play with everybody in the world.

MR: Was it here where you won the Major Bowes contest?

TG: Yeah. I grew up in Brooklyn. And I was a Major Bowes. But I was thirteen, in fact, last December was 64 years that I'd been on the road. I know every cockroach in every hotel in the world. I've been on the road — you name it — the cockroaches became my friends. There's a few in this hotel.

MR: Was there something in your family that led you into music?

TG: Is that why you brought it up, with the cockroaches? Actually all the family, we're all musicians. My father, my brother played xylophone and always had it in the house, so when he wouldn't be around, I was very athletic, boxing, and playing football and baseball. When he wasn't around I'd doodle on the thing you know. And then I went up, when I was about eleven or so I went up to a resort where my brother was playing, and they used to have an amateur hour. Monday night would be like your amateur hour style. But my brother was playing drums with the band and when he wasn't around I'd go in the casino and I learned the "Boulevard of Broken Dreams." That song. [scats] It's an old song. Anyhow some lady, a rich lady, came in and caught me playing. She says, "You've got to play in the amateur hour." I says, "No, don't tell my brother, it's my fanny if you do that, I'm not supposed to be touching his instruments." And she says — anyhow, he

found out about it. And that weekend my sister happened to be visiting. And then when they told her I was going to be in an amateur hour, nobody knew I even played the instrument. Nobody. My brother didn't know it, my sister didn't know it. But later on I would doodle. And she heard me play it, and I really played well, and got me a teacher later on, and I went on to learn. And the Major Bowes Amateur Hour and I've been on the road since then.

MR: Amazing.

TG: Yeah I've been very fortunate. That cliché, being in the right time at the right time, a lot of that has happened for me.

MR: The music of the day, when you were a youngster, radio was extremely important, right?

TG: Uh huh.

MR: Is that where you got most of your exposure?

TG: Well no, they had the big bands at the Paramount Theater and the Strand Theater. Never in my born days did I ever think I would ever work with Benny Goodman. When I was a kid I'd be the first one in line, five or six o'clock in the morning, to get in the Paramount Theater. And when that stage would go up in the old days, and people would go to the Paramount Theater, that stage used to rise. And while it was going up from the pit, Benny would be playing the theme song "Let's Dance." My hair would stand up. And that was one of my favorite bands. And then when I got to work with him, it was amazing. And then when I got to work with him I found out what an idiot he was. Complete foggy idiot. But he could play the clarinet.

MR: He could. What's that, there's some story I heard about Gubenko, him calling someone Gubenko.

TG: Well he always called me Gubenko. He calls anybody Pops. Well I'll tell you. Well I know maybe the story you're talking about. He always called everybody Pops and he always called me Gubenko. He loved that name. Now we're doing the Ed Sullivan Show. And this goes, naturally it's much more of a story than just the Gubenko. We're doing the Ed Sullivan Show and there was one show that Teddy Wilson couldn't be on because he had other commitments. So they hired a piano player called Bernie Leighton. White guy. Blondish hair. Now Benny couldn't remember anybody's name ever. Now we rehearsed all week with Ed Sullivan, playing on one song. We played this song, went off to the right. Played, off. Played one, same song. You do that so the cameras can get their shots, you know. And Benny didn't say one word to Bernie Leighton. This whole seven days. He didn't even look at him. Didn't even know Teddy Wilson wasn't going to be the piano player. Now it comes the show time and we do the playing our song, and as we're playing I supposed Ed Sullivan got the sign to stretch. On television when they give you this it means we need a little more time. So all of a sudden, we finish our song, and

Benny's about ready to walk to the right and he says, "Hey Benny." Now Benny gets a little curve. He never heard that in rehearsal at all. Now walking off he threw a curve and Ed Sullivan was in left field himself, so you get two guys up there, and he says to Benny, "Benny, who's in the band?" Because he had to ask to kill some time. And Benny looks over at the band and looks at me first, he tried to say Terry, he tried his best, "Uhh Gubenko." My mother loved it, my relatives loved it, whoa, what a hit. But then he got the other guys names and he gets to Bernie Leighton and he looks at the piano player he hasn't even looked at all week, and he says, "On piano, Teddy Wilson." Now we all made a double take. Now the whole world knows that Teddy Wilson is a famous black piano player. Bernie is as white as you can get. When he said, "Teddy Wilson," the whole band made a double — we had to look and see who was playing piano? What an idiot. On national — probably the biggest show on television at that time. But when he said, "Gubenko," like I said my whole family, all the Jews in Brooklyn loved it.

MR: That's a good one. He was pretty, I guess, just totally centered on the music. Was that what he was about?

TG: Yeah he was really — you know if he checked into a hotel, if he was on 37, 40, you went to 22 whatever on the other side. Because he'd practice all day. He lived the clarinet, he really did. He was so foggy, really. The only time he ever knew what he was doing was when he played the clarinet. He couldn't remember names.

MR: How did he hold a band together? Was that someone else's job really?

TG: Well he chose the musicians he wanted. He had a manager of course, you know that man. I'll tell you how foggy — now Sid Weiss, the bass player that worked with Benny Goodman on the old band, an old timer, he told me that in the old days, of course I really, Benny liked me and I had a bad temper in those days and I almost hit him actually. And I used to tell him — I can't use that f word. But you foggy idiot. You know, a foggy idiot. Because he would do some of the dumbest things. And I was just a kid. You know I didn't know any — and Sid Weiss said nobody in life ever talked to him, because he didn't know anybody. One time they were going to do a tour with Benny Goodman and they were trying to get all the original guys that were still alive and — this is a true story — and Louis Armstrong's band. Before I tell you this, when I worked with him I once asked him — I said I wanted to be around him all day. I was so in awe of him. I said, "Benny, who was your favorite lead trumpet player?" And I'm following him around like a little kid, pulling the string. He said, "Bunny Berigan and Doug Mettome." I said, "What did you think of Harry James?" He says, "I didn't know him." And he walks away from me. I said wait a minute. "Harry James." "I didn't know him." Now that's what Sid Weiss told me, that he didn't know one guy from another. Now they get this whole thing together. Joe Glaser, the agent, who is his agent, got as many guys as he can. Georgie

Auld, got everybody. And the most important thing is that Benny said to Joe Glaser, "Get me Ziggy Elman." Now I came in with them to the rehearsal and Benny looks at Joe Glaser, looks around to him. He said, "I told you to get me Ziggy Elman." He says, "That's Ziggy." "That's not Ziggy Elman." "What do you mean?" He walked away. He didn't know Ziggy from Harry from Chris Griffin. He didn't whose name was who. "Get me Ziggy Elman." But when it came to playing the clarinet, that was probably some of the most greatest thrills I've ever had in my whole life. He can play.

MR: He really could. Let me go back a little bit. You did some service in World War II.

TG: Yeah.

MR: What kind of service did you do?

TG: Well it's wild. They don't tell you in the Army what you're going to do. Want me to tell you my first experiences in the Army?

MR: Yeah.

TG: I was very young and I couldn't talk, I used to box. I wanted to be a fighter. And there was one, you know when you first go in they send you to I think Fort Dix, the big camp where before they send you out to wherever you're going to go, they get thousands of guys there and all you do is walk around picking up cigarette butts. They have to kill time until they find a place where you're going to go. Well 39 years old I think was the age where you got dis— you couldn't get in the Army after 39. And I was 18. And this one guy was a PFC, kept picking on this guy who at that time I thought was an old guy, because I was 18 and he was 39. I thought he was old. Now he could be my grandson. I thought he was old. And so he kept picking at him. And so I said, "Hey listen, why don't you give the rest of us something to do, you know, he's an older guy here." He takes me out and he says, "What's your name?" I thought he was going to make me a sergeant, what do you mean. So I told him Private Julius Gubenko." He says, "What barracks?" He took down the name. General the next day, you know. Four o'clock in the morning, that guy came in, "Gubenko?" I said, "Yeah." "You're on K.P." He said, "I know you have to do that," and you serve thousands of guys. And then whenever you serve them then you go home usually. "Gubenko, you guys stay and you have to clean out the pots and pans." I'm talking about funky pots and pans. So I did that and I went back to bed about two o'clock in the morning. Four o'clock in the morning, again, the same guy woke me up for K.P. and I went through the same thing. And the next night he did it again. And now I knew what he was doing, because of what I did and I said, "Listen, why don't we go outside and fight and get this over with?" No fighting, you do K.P. He wouldn't fight me and he had me do K.P. for five days until I didn't say a word. I mean it taught me something. I finally got shipped out, but I was done. K.P., you name it. But then I got into — guys who were about 24 years old were in bands. At 18 you were a baby and they

were much older to me too. I went into the Eighth Armored Division as a tank driver. And you know, like I say, in the Army they don't tell you what you're going to do. So I was a tank driver, I was driving a tank. Then they put me in the band. They put me in the band because they needed — nobody played vibes. I wanted to play drums so bad, really, but they didn't have vibes so they put me in the band. Now the infiltration course is where they have barbed wire about this high and you have to crawl underneath through mud with the thing exploding. And this is World War II where there is no games. We had to beat Hitler and his gang, where they actually shot real bullets overhead, real bullets. Because if you sit up you can get hurt, killed, but if you did it overseas you can kill everybody else because — so that was the training. So I did that and I was ready to go overseas and they don't tell you, Private Gubenko, once again, they ship me to Dallas, Texas, they put together a band to make music, the Army picks it. And they need a percussion player. So I would be up playing drums in the band, which I wanted to do, with 30 strings and all, a big thing, and I'd play some vibes once in a while too, because they had a bunch of drummers. And I wound up writing a lot of arrangements, doing the whole thing. Never could get a rating, because also in those days we used to listen to Woody Herman's band on the radio and Davy Tough was playing drums and when Davy would finish the song it would be cut off and he goes [scats] he did some extra beats. So every time in the band, boy I was hip you know. He'd cut us off and I'd go [scats]. He says, "Hey what are you doing, I gave you a cut off." I says, "Yeah, but Davy Tough." He says, "I don't care about Davy Tough or Woody Herman. And I never could get — when I got discharged, like eighty years later, I was finally a corporal. I finally kept my mouth shut. If you're not the band leader, don't say anything. But it took a while.

MR: I have a feeling you still have to get the last word in.

TG: No, no. Only from the band. You know something? When I worked with Steve Allen for years, conducting, my job was to conduct. There's a director and a producer. Whatever they have to tell me. But if it comes to my department, they hire me to do the job, I'll tell them. Otherwise don't give me that job. And I'll take a lot of advice of musicians. The thing is, but I don't do record — when I first moved to California I'd go to do a record date and there'd be some idiot up there and we'd be doing 84 takes and I'd want to say, "Make that an E flat and that would solve the problem, we could go straight ahead." But you can't do that because everybody wants to make overtime money. It's a business. You know they want — they'd stay there twenty hours because it gets to a certain time, double money. I couldn't stand there, so I never would do studio work because of that. The music would be — I didn't care how good or bad it was because there was always good musicians playing it. It's just that sometimes the band leader, he didn't know, because the guy that writes the arrangements sometimes, they're not band leaders, they're

good arrangers, and sometimes when it came to the rock era, there'd be no music, they didn't even know what they're doing. You get a lead sheet, and you have to make up your own part half the time. But then again you'd stay there hours because it's an E flat chord. If he would just say "E flat" and we all played it, that would solve the whole problem. But he'd mention everything but E flat. And the guys loved it because they'd go home with a lot of money. And that wasn't for me. The music has always been the most important thing.

MR: Uh huh. Where did you learn the harmony required to play the vibes?

TG: Well I studied with a German teacher. I had a scholarship to Juilliard as a timpanist. Want to hear one of my funny stories as a timpanist?

MR: Absolutely.

TG: In school, you know, when you hear big symphonies, and the orchestra gets exciting, the timpanist never has a lot to play. Sometimes I had to count a hundred bars and then go ba-ba-ba-boom, ba-boom. A hundred bars and sixty more, boom. Then the orchestra would get exciting and I used to sneak in and make my own parts up. I'd make them up to be exciting with the band. And every fifth day I'd get caught. Every fifth day the band leader would say to me, "Gubenko" he says, "what are you doing?" He says, "Letter C." I says, "Oh letter C, I was letter D." He says, "No, you idiot, it was letter C." So then for five days more I'd play the part like it was written, ba-ba-boom. And then I'd start sneaking. Because I always thought there should be more timpanis when the orchestra got exciting — that bottom with the timpani you know. But that's how they're writing. Five days for him, five days for me.

MR: That's great. So you got some classical —quote — training.

TG: Yeah.

MR: And that allowed you to do some arranging later on?

TG: Well I learned, well I did a lot of writing of songs, a lot of writing of compositions, a lot. I've written about three hundred, and about 280 of them have been recorded, but mostly by myself, but I've had Nat Cole record a few tunes and Count Basie and Woody Herman and Cannonball Adderley and George Shearing just recently recorded. I don't push my songs. I feel strange pushing songs on people. But sometimes they hear them and I get a call, did you write this? Recently, in the last few years, Nat Cole recorded two of my tunes back in 1948, we were on tour with Woody Herman and we were backstage, you know, everybody's through, the band boys were packing up and I'm sitting at the piano and I'm doodling. And Nat was standing by me and he says, "What's that song?" I said, "It's a tune I wrote called 'Peaches.'" "Let me hear it." And so I showed him the tune. He said,"Do you mind if I record it?" That's when he had the trio, you know? I said, "Be my guest." He said, "You got anything else I'd like?" So I showed him another one. And he

recorded both of them. Now not much records sold in those days, but that was 1948. Now — and he died and they weren't pushing his records. Now Natalie Cole comes out with that "Unforgettable" with her dad, and piecing that thing together. So that made Nat a little hot too, they started re-releasing his records. And "Peaches" came out again. And that brought me a little money. And then George Shearing, about a year and a half ago did an album called "A Tribute to Nat Cole" and recorded that song. Someone told me years ago, never give away your publishing rights. Can I drink while we're talking?

MR: Please, yeah, absolutely.

TG: Well then give me something better — no.

MR: Oh my, yeah that's good, because that stuff doesn't go away. You never know when it's coming back.

TG: It's great when this happens. It makes me feel good. George Shearing, there were many more things he could have recorded but he picked that tune.

MR: You and Chubby Jackson—

TG: I laugh when I hear the name.

MR: That must have been quite a combination.

TG: I was talking to him about it a week ago.

MR: Really. How's he doing?

TG: Not good. In fact, I'm glad, the last time I talked to him I felt good because a month and a half or two months ago when I talked to him, he's got kidney failure. And he was not going to take the dialysis. He's not going to do that. He says, "I lived a good life, I'm 82, I want to go out—" I said, "Chubby, you're crazy." "Well Terry—" Anyhow I called him about, oh just a few days before I came here, a few days ago, and he changed his mind. He's going to do that now. Three days a week, and I'm glad for him. Because his mind is still so sharp and funny. Chubby's out there. The worst band leader in the world, the worst band leader for the simple reason that in the old days you used to do 40 on, 20 off, 40 on, 20 off. We would do an hour and a half and then go away for an hour and a half. We never played the same place twice, ever. The band was swinging, why get off after 40 minutes? He'd be talking and carrying on, he'd never look at his watch and say we're back on again. I mean the club owner would have us fired.

MR: Yeah? Who else was in that group when you were playing with him?

TG: In the group?

MR: Yeah.

TG: We went to Sweden with that group. Conte Candoli, Lou Levy and Frank Socolow on tenor and Denzel Best on drums. And Conte and Lou Levy both had played in my Dream Band. Both of them.

MR: What was your first reaction to Europe like? The first time you went?

TG: It was amazing. I mean the reaction of the audience for the musicians. I didn't believe it. The first concert we played after we got done, 84,000 flowers were put on stage. I never saw — for a jazz concert? I never saw that. But jazz musicians, especially this was 1946 I think it was or early '47. The jazz musician was treated like Toscanini, like a symphony musician, got the same feeling you get from the audience, they gave you that feeling of greatness. They appreciate what you did. And you were treated like royalty. It's a little different now. You know it's still good, they fill up jazz there you know—

MR: Yeah, but it's not quite like you're conquering heroes or—

TG: Well not so much anymore. In a few years of going to Europe, I'll tell you, the cocky American.

MR: Yeah, ah, okay.

TG: I mean not really, let's face it, the jazz musicians in America are the best. They are the best. So I think, and also I think some of the countrymen have resented the jazz musicians taking some of their ladies away to the United States, so that wasn't a good thing either.

MR: I see.

TG: Not me. Not me. Thank God. I've been married now, this time, for 23 years. And my wife is the greatest thing that ever lived. Anybody who will put up with me for 23 years, you know has got to be a complete — well she's out of it probably. My wife is saying it don't make any sense. She doesn't understand half of the things I say to her. She just comes right out and — that's why she's with me.

MR: Well that's right. Hope she never does.

TG: You know, another 25 years, "I know what he said 20 years ago now." It'll come to her.

MR: I read a humorous anecdote about you and Buddy Rich.

TG: About the leaving me in the desert?

MR: Yeah.

TG: That's been in a million — I'm doing a book right now.

MR: Good.

TG: And the first chapter has been sent in. I gave them the television chapter because they know I'm a jazz musician, there'll be a lot about jazz musicians, and I gave him the Steve Allen and Regis Philbins and Don Rickles and the Milton Berles, and all the things I had something to do with my television experience. So they liked it. Now when I get back, I'm writing with a gentleman called Cary Ginell, who produced an NPR show, a Nancy Wilson thing, for my 75th birthday. And he's editing the thing with me. So we just did a chapter, which they wanted, on the Woody Herman Four Brothers band. And I could talk about things now that I couldn't ten years ago. Because unfortunately there was a lot of dope in that band. A lot of junkies. Sick guys. Which I wouldn't talk about and mention

names. But I can talk about it now. Because I look for humor in everything. Things that weren't funny then, I can look now and they were funny but tragic at the same time.

MR: Did some of the fellas that were into that suffer later on? Even if they got over it?

TG: They — Stan Getz, Zoot Sims, Al Cohn and Serge Chaloff all died I think from cirrhosis of the liver. Even though they quit. Even when they quit though, they were all drinking. Stan Getz would drink a fifth of liquor and it wouldn't bother him like it would the guy who never made that. But they were all straight later on. But I think what happened is it affected them. It stays in your system I suppose. Thank God I never did that, and let me tell you one of the reasons. Two things. I like to laugh. And all the junkies I've seen they don't even laugh, they're just like falling asleep. And the second reason, which is the most important reason, is I am afraid of a needle. When I go to the doctor for a shot in my fanny of penicillin, he's got to catch me before I get — then I'll take that thing if I get a cold. Needles don't do anything for me. Not my favorite thing in the world.

MR: It must have been hard for Woody to deal with that.

TG: I admire him so much because he put up with so much. And the reason he put up with it, that was the greatest band in the world at that time. The greatest band. It was so great that instead of playing one night stands and barns or ballroom or whatever, where you make your money, we stayed at the Royal Roost in New York for a month, in California at the Empire Room for a month, Chicago at the Blue Note for a month, and you can't make any money in night clubs. No way can you pay a sixteen, seventeen piece band and come out. No way can you do it. And so he'd lose money all the time. But he was so proud of that band. Really proud. Because it was the greatest band in the world. Every one of those guys in that band, the Four Brothers Band, went on to become big jazz stars or movie picture writers, arrangers.

MR: Yeah, you were playing some great arrangements, huh?

TG: Shorty Rogers, Ralph Burns, Johnny Mandel, you name it. Neal Hefti. You go down the list of guys. Two of my close friends, Neal Hefti, and Johnny Mandel even more than Neal because I sort of grew up with Johnny, he was my roommate on the Buddy Rich band, they make so much money on — not so much on the songs that they wrote that are popular like for example "The Shadow of Your Smile," "Emily," "A Time for Love," that Johnny Mandel wrote and Neal wrote "Cute" and "L'il Darling" and all these things — they wrote theme songs for two of the biggest shows that are being played all over the world now. Neal wrote the Odd Couple theme song, and Johnny wrote "MASH." So that goes on, the royalties come in for that every time, all over the world, that keeps being played.

MR: Good deal.

TG: And they're both good guys so I'm happy for both of them.

MR: Yeah. A lot of — sometimes the names that would show up as you watch those things would really surprise me. Like I'm forgetting who did Batman.

TG: Neal Hefti.

MR: Neal Hefti, right.

TG: You know what, he told me a lot of this recently. Now the Odd Couple is being played, every time I'm in Europe, you name it, anywhere, I see it all the time — but he told me he makes more money from Batman. And he's such a giant arranger. And harmonically he could write. Batman is the dumbest thing, it's like one note, Batman. And he made a fortune.

MR: Well it fit the TV show for sure.

TG: Oh yeah. He knew what he was doing.

MR: What prompted you to move from one coast to the other?

TG: Well I got burned out to start with. I was married to a lady and we got divorced. Because I met her in California and we got married. I was 24, she was about 18. I moved to California, and I'd leave her here. I lived in New York, I'd leave her here, and I'd go on the road for eight, nine months at a time. And we had no life. I mean I was bad. I was really bad in those days. And so we got divorced and about six months later we started talking again, you know, saying if I would stay home more maybe we could work it out. And I was really burnt out with the group I had for four years on the road, working anywhere from 48 to 52 weeks a year. It was hard. Like I said with Birdland six months a year, and the time on the road, so I figured we'll move out to California, because she was from California, and I'll do studio work and we'll see what can happen. And I moved out to California and I was burnt out and I was ready to do studio work. Because I play all the percussion instruments. And I called a guy called Al Lapin who was the biggest contractor. He was NBC, the biggest contractor at NBC, plus a million other things. And he knew my father and he knew my reputation. So I called him and I asked him, I'd like to go on staff. He says, "I don't know" he says, "I got 82 musicians, I don't know if we can use any more musicians." So two weeks went by where from being burnt out I rejuvenated. I got all that energy and I found out now that if you go on staff you can't play clubs or anything, because they had what they called a quota. They wanted all the musicians to work and all the best musicians were in the studios, they would also work clubs and the other guys wouldn't have the jobs. It was a quota. So I found out if I went on staff, and I was already having a nervous breakdown not playing for two weeks. And so Al Lapin called me back and he says, "I'm going to put you on staff." I said, "Listen, Al, I have to have a double check." You won't believe — I can't— "The only guys that get the double checks — are you kidding, are you crazy?" And he mentioned two guys. Conrad Gozzo, who is a lead trumpet player, and Irv Cottler, who played drums with

Frank Sinatra for 20 years. "Are you kidding? Forget about it. Goodbye." He hung up on me. I got a call about three days later. And then he said, "Listen, I'm going to put you on staff." And I knew the reason why. The reason why was because I used to do these television — like Dinah Shore Show — as a guest. Now they don't have to pay me because they can put me on these shows. So he was going to put me on. So in the long run NBC would save money. Then I had to tell him, "Al," I said, "I love you and all, but I can't do it, only because I've still got to play some jazz and being on staff I couldn't." So I went through a scene with him for three weeks. You wouldn't believe how he screamed, yelled. He was so powerful. The most powerful contractor we ever had in show business, in NBC. Not only NBC, all the orchestras, plus all the record dates and everything else. If I ever went on NBC I could have done millions of record dates because he would have liked what I done you know. But I had to play. It went back to the music, see?

MR: Yeah, absolutely. Tell me about what possessed you to try to get your Dream Band going? The big band?

TG: That was just a fluke. It was the biggest fluke. I recorded a band in New York in 1956 or something like that and I was sick because it wasn't good — not to me, it wasn't good. I used the same rhythm section that was with my little group. I always try to use the guys who travel with me and kill themselves on the road, to give them a good job. If I did a T.V. show, I was steadily using a quartet, three of the guys from the house band, I want my guys on there. I always tried to push them on there. So I put them on the big band record date, and the most important thing is the drummer, and he didn't know how to play with a big band. And we did it, I went to the first date, I was sick. Nothing was happening. We had the greatest players. I got all the guys that used to be in Woody's band, all the greatest players in New York. Ernie Wilkins writing, Manny Albam writing, Johnny Mandel. All the best arrangers. And it was so bad that it got me sick. I caught a cold and the best thing about it, the drummer — I won't mention the name because he's not alive anyhow — he came over to me after the first record date and he said, "Terry, I don't think I'm making it if you want to get another drummer." And I thanked him. And I got Osie Johnson, who was one of the better drummers in those days. But by that time I was so sick that I — mentally it screwed me up. Because it was something I wanted to do all my life. You know the record, when I hear it now it's not bad. But nothing compared to what I wanted to hear. And so I didn't play on the date. I was there and I conducted the whole thing. I overdubbed all my choruses, because I couldn't play and it just threw me off. But then the Dream Band, how that happened, I moved out to California, and had a great contract with Mercury. I almost could record any time I had an idea of something different. I could do four or five albums a year. Now Bill Holman had a rehearsal band and Med Flory had a rehearsal band. And I liked what I heard. And I had an idea. The

idea was I was going to hire six different arrangers and pay tribute to six different band leaders, like Duke Ellington, Lionel Hampton, Count Basie, Tommy Dorsey, Benny Goodman and Artie Shaw. And I was going to take something out of each arrangement, like Artie Shaw's clarinet chorus on "Stardust" just the first 16 bars, and somewhere would sneak it in the arrangement, or part of Ben Webster's chorus on "Cottontail," whatever, you know. And I hired the arrangers that I thought would write for those guys. I put Bill Holman writing the Artie Shaw thing because Bill had that melodic kind of thing. Even though they all had melodic things, Al Cohn, I gave him the Duke Ellington things, and Manny Albam the Basie things. I gave it to the guys that I thought would do it. Now I get all this music, ready to rehearse it. And once again I found out in California that you cannot rehearse for a record date. I won't mention the guy's name — I was fined a thousand dollars. In fact it was like probably getting fined twenty today for rehearsing for a record date. Because they want you to go into the studio and make the money overtime. The union wants you to make the money. You know you can rehearse the song 25 times until you get it right.

MR: But they want you in the studio.

TG: Yeah. Well I was going to do this in the studio. This was done in the studio. But they want you in the studio, not rehearsing in a hall somewhere. So I had all this music. In the meantime there was a club that was going to close call The Seville. And the movie columnist called Eve Star took a liking to how I played and she knew the club owner at The Seville, and they were going to go out of business. They tried Latin, they tried all this, they had to try jazz. So they hired me with a quintet. They said five musicians. Now being an out-of-towner I got decent money. The scale was only $15 but I got much more than that, and we did — on a Tuesday night — we did fairly good for them. And so we did it again the next Tuesday. In the meantime I heard that you are allowed to rehearse for a nightclub engagement, even though you can't for a record date, so what I did is I said to the guy, "How'd you like to have a fifteen piece band for what you're paying me for five musicians?" Because I had enough. The scale was $15 at that time. I had enough to pay everybody scale. He says, "I don't care if you get four million" he says, "we don't do any business I'm going to close anyhow." So I got a chance to rehearse. We expected 20 people, 25 people to come in the club. They sold 300 you know. The 20 people would have paid enough to maybe, with drinking and all, to pay the tab, which would have been the quintet. Steve Allen at that time was just a friend of mine. I didn't work for him. He gave me a little plug. We recorded all day—I rehearsed it all, for two or three days. Went in the club. Sure enough like I thought, after all day, 20 people, that's all we expected. I went in the back room, because all we had was 12 arrangements that we recorded, and in those days did three and four shows a night. So we went in the back room with the 12

pieces of music and I said, "On this song on letter B, Conte you play a hundred choruses, on C Frank Rosolino, you have two thousand choruses," we had to open it up. We'll make backgrounds you know. And so we started to walk out to play, and there were 300 people packed in the club with a line waiting to get in. And you saw faces like Fred McMurray and Ginger Rodgers. All these movie stars. And all the musicians in town. So I called the band back in the dressing room. I said, "We're starting a band tonight, but there's one rule. There's no drinking off the bandstand. If you want to drink you have to drink on stage." You never saw a wilder scene in your life. The audience couldn't get a drink. I turned around and saw Med Flory, "Here, I have to have a beer, Terry. Wait a second. Waitress." We'd have five waitresses on the stage giving everybody beers, whatever they drink. The audience is waiting for a drink. But you couldn't get in the club. And immediately we were the talk of Hollywood. So we said let's do it again next week. Sure enough we come to work, 9:30, 20 people. We figured it was a fluke. Went in the back room, by that time Bill Holman lent me an arrangement, Med Flory lent me an arrangement, I had about sixteen arrangements. We had to talk over what we were going to do with that. And by the time we came out to play at 10:00, you couldn't get in. Packed, a line around the corner. It was ridiculous. More movie stars. You know Louella Parsons, you know that name?

MR: Yeah.

TG: She was and old time movie columnist who could make you or break you, you know, in the movie business. She'd be sitting there. It didn't make any sense that people were coming to see the band. And we were the heroes. We played — $15 a night and our bar tabs were $23. You've got to be an idiot to do that. We were having so much fun. We didn't care about the music. And that went on for about five weeks in a row. It was Mondays, maybe two nights a week. Then the club owner says, "Why don't we do this five nights a week starting —" I said, "You really want to try it?" "Yeah," he said, "let's do it." In the meantime I didn't realize that Count Basie was opening right down about two blocks down in the place called the Crescendo. Now it's a hard thing to say but we got scared. But we outdrew Basie's band to a point where his band was in our club every time they had intermission, they were all there. They didn't believe the band. Nobody did. I mean it was one of these things that, they were such a hit then but then again, once again, after I gave up the band in 1962, that was the end of that. And Buddy Rich and Shorty Rogers would come up to my house. See I had these tapes. When I recorded the band actually for records, Wally Heider had recorded the band, I'd auditioned Wally Heider at The Seville. I'd heard about him and I wanted to hear what he did. So he came in the club and he recorded the band, because I wanted to do a live album. And we'd go back to the studio and he'd play for me and I'd say, "Wally, that's 95% good but let me

tell you what I need now." I'm the band leader, there was something I wanted to hear. You know, right or wrong, I wanted to hear something that I wanted. It started with, "You hear how the lead trumpet player, how you can hear him so well?" "Yeah." I said, "Now let me hear the fourth trumpet player. All four trumpets. On the same level." I wanted to hear the sound of a band, not protruding notes. Now great, now you hear? In the old days, by the way, it was hard to record the bass. All you heard was boom-boom-boom-boom-boom because everything was done almost on one track, or not even two tracks, just put into the thing. So I brought him a record of "Jack the Bear" by Duke Ellington, where you hear [scats]. I said that's what I want to hear. I want to hear notes. Now the next thing, I don't want to feel the drums, you put the drums up front. That's the fire of the whole band. Put Mel Lewis up in front. We came in the next day and did that. We came in for a few days and did that. Perfect. By that time we moved to another club to record, and I had all these tapes in my house. And what it was, it was songs that we played before that we recorded before. 27 years I had those tapes in my house. Buddy Rich would come over and Shorty Rogers. And I had them on reel to reel. And they said, "Why don't you put these out? It's the greatest band in the world." I said, "It's only for you and I to listen to. Forget about it." And then all of a sudden the band started to make noise. Rob McConnell, Bob Florence, Frank Capp— and I'm sitting with the greatest thing so I figured well — and also another thing it was the days of records and cassettes. And by the time we opened up our things, it would start out to be an ensemble band, of course after we opened it all up for solos I said the last four minutes was ensemble. We went home hollering, the whole band. Now the records and the tapes that Wally Heider recorded when we opened it up, they were like 15 minutes each, and records, you could only put about 20 minutes on each side. Now I didn't want to cut them because it was some of the greatest soloists — so I wouldn't do it. Then in 1986 Dick Bach, who owned Pacific Records, heard the records. First Gene Norman, do you know who Gene Norman is? He's got a record label called Crescendo. The older Crescendo night club that I worked at with Woody Herman's band, he heard them and he wanted to buy them all. But I said I'll sell them to you if you put it out in a four package set without cutting them up. He said, "I can't make any money there, Terry. I've got to chop this up so I can make a record out of it." I said, "Forget about it." Unless you buy all four as a package set — and he offered me a lot of money — and I passed. Then all these bands came out and Dick Bach came and said, "Terry" — and he's a great editor — he said, "let me show you something." And for example he took Opus Number 1, where there was a battle, it was about 15 minutes long, and about 9 minutes of it was Joe Maini and Charlie Kennedy, the two alto players, playing two choruses each, then one each, then sixteen bars each, eight bars each, four bars, two bars, one bar each. And then into the next thing. And I didn't

want that cut out. He said, “Let me show you. Let me do something for you. Don’t listen to those things at all anymore,” which I hardly ever did because they were on reel to reel. And he cut it to where we made it into a five minute thing where it was almost like it started out, the ensemble, it was an ensemble. Because that was what made the band. Even though we had the greatest soloists, there was the fire of the ensemble, because they played so well together. I mean you find a lot of bands playing but not everybody thought like we did. If you took each guy out in the band on the street and said, “Who is your favorite alto player, who’s your favorite trumpet player, favorite piano player?” Same names. Charlie Parker, Dizzy Gillespie, Bud Powell. That was our idols. So because of loving the same people, we all felt the same way about the music. So Dick Bach anyway did that, and I did miss the rest of the choruses but he really knew how to cut it. He cut it great. So I agreed to do that. And all I got was $2,500. I paid all the guys myself to put it out. But I did have the use Fantasy, and I made very good friends with Ralph Kaffel later on, the president of Fantasy, who is one of my close friends now. He gave me the use of the Fantasy telephone, their number, to charge every phone call to make sure I can call every disc jockey in the world and charge it to them and make sure, if they don’t have a CD they’ll get one immediately. So I used to get up at 6:00 in the morning. First of all, what happened is when the record first came out we had two radio stations in California, two jazz stations. I’d put on one and all of a sudden I’d hear five of the songs. Then I’d put on the other one and I’d hear four or five more. It became the biggest hit. In California they were playing it, but I didn’t know they were playing it all over. But I would call every disc jockey, and if they didn’t have one — I’d have to get up at 6:00 in the morning in California, because here it’s 9:00 on the west coast. In Europe it’s another time. So sometimes I’d be sitting there at 6:00 in the morning in my underwear and it would be like 8:00 at night and I’m still sitting there, hadn’t had anything to eat. On the phone. Because I didn’t believe what was happening. And the band made a success all over the world. To a point where when Buddy and I went to Europe this last time, we did about sixteen, seventeen one nighters in England, and the promoter brought our CDs that Buddy and I did to sell. And the Europeans, they are very brave, they just walk in your dressing room, they just walk in, didn’t even knock on the door, walk in, to sign autographs. And not only did they come with the Buddy DeFranco Terry Gibbs album, but every little town, everybody would have all five CDs of the Dream Band. At least four or five guys in every town. I never knew it got out that far. And it really made that much noise. Now they are being sold, copies of the original arrangements. No new copies are being made of the things that Joe Maini marked in and what Mel Lewis marked in. Just like they was, they’re being sold. Dave Pell, who has the octet, he distributes them for me.

MR: That's great.

TG: And colleges are buying them left and right. I was just doing a clinic and a few of the college people said, "Are you kidding, we ordered fourteen." Because they don't write arrangements like that anymore. They're just straight ahead swing music. And especially if you want to show the band off, if you play the arrangements like it's really written, because I actually patterned the band after the Benny Goodman band because Benny played in and out. Because it didn't blend with the section. It did, but it would sound like Glenn Miller with the clarinet and the saxes. And vibes, it just was a bastard instrument. So I wrote it, they were all written where vibes go in and out, you know. So if you play it down just like it's written, a lot of ensemble, I says, "Give me a lot of ensemble. I've got sixteen men, I want to hear sixteen musicians." So the band really hit big. But that's how it happened, by a fluke thing. Then the band — you couldn't get in — anywhere we played. Even today, there's about four guys, five guys, that are still left from the original. Because most of them are dead. A lot of them are dead unfortunately, Richie Kamuca is dead, Mel Lewis is dead, Buddy Clarke is dead, Joe Maini is dead, Ray Cheschare, Frank Rosolino. But there's guys that have been working for me for thirty years now, when I put the band together. And so every once in a while, that cliché, when they make me an offer I can't refuse. But now they're all leaders by the way. Med Flory, Frank Capp. When they make me an offer I can't refuse. Because I refuse to not pay a guy. Because they've been with me for forty years, where they'll work around town locally for $70 or $100 to have fun with bands, I won't take a job unless I can pay them three and four times that amount of money. And so, and I want to make some money, so I cliché, when they make me an offer I can't refuse, I put the band together. And it's the biggest headache in the world. Because I've got seventeen band leaders. But I like that. The music they take serious. When I go to make an announcement, I love if they become a bunch of idiots and scream and yell and whatever they want to do. Because the audience loves that. In fact the last concert we just did two months ago, Med Flory, things just happen in my band that start off something with an audience rapport, they happen immediately. I say some dumb things when I first come out. And we have an arrangement, Opus Number 1 that opened up. We play, then there's a little interlude and then there's a battle between the altos. Med Flory plays two choruses, Lanny Morgan plays two choruses, then it goes like the same thing, eights, fours, twos and ones. And Med was tired that night. So we are playing the first chorus, now it gets to the point where he's got to play his alto chorus, and I don't know what the hell, I see him pick up the clarinet. He forgot to turn the page. So the next page he has to play the clarinet. And he's playing all alone. But he was playing an alto solo. And he's "Ut, oh," then he picked up the alto. The audience immediately broke up, and it happened. And what made it even

better, he still forgot to turn the page over, so he came in again, and I have to play after that, the vibes play. Then comes the clarinet. So he's picking up the clarinet and he's playing all alone while I'm playing my solo. Then he realizes what he's doing. Once again the audience fell out, and you know what? That was the standard thing through the whole hour and a half we do. I'd asked Med, "Med, you want to sing?" "Anything you want, Terry." And Med's very funny. All the guys. You know I play straight man for anybody in that band.

MR: That's great stories.

TG: Oh I love that band.

MR: Let me play something for you.

TG: Okay.

MR: From your past.

TG: Oh God it'll probably be terrible. I hate things I did in the past.

[audio interlude]

TG: Is that Gus Bivona and myself? At Joe Pasternak's house.

MR: That's right. That's right. I have this— you know who that was?

TG: Allen's All Stars.

MR: Yeah.

TG: I was wild. Pete Rugolo, who was then the A&R person, the producer was called the artists and repertoire man. He was the producer. And I wanted to do a live date. Because Steve and I became very good friends. And the fact that he was living in New York, and he bought a home in California, and every time he'd come to visit his children he'd give me a call and — it was empty, the house. And I'd call and we'd jam. And I got bummed, when Jayne moved out here they made a house out of it, and took away our jam session house. They put furniture in and ruined the whole house. So when Steve came out one time I said, "Let's do something." So I told Pete Rugolo, we used to do live dates at a party, and Pete was in with all the Hollywood crowd. And I don't think many of the young people or older people may not remember the name Joe Pasternak. He was the biggest producer of musicals. Judy Garland and Mickey Rooney. All those musicals he produced. So we did it at his house. And he loved it. We did it as out and out fun.

MR: Yeah. Sounds great.

TG: It was a party.

MR: You were —

[audio interlude]

TG: You know I hate to listen to old things I did. Oh I don't hate to, but what's good about listening to them, I remember that time. What was going on in my life at that time. It was a fun time.

MR: Good.

TG: In fact that band, that size band is what I used when I was conducting with Steve. The sextet. With the clarinet, guitar and vibes, and piano, bass and drums.

MR: How did you get to know him?

TG: Well I got to know him, he was a fan of mine. [pause for refreshment] That's right keep bringing 'em in. Stop putting all that vodka in this. I quit drinking years ago. I thank you very much. He was a fan of mine. He used to come, in New York, when I played Birdland. He'd come in all the time to hear me. And when I moved out to California he'd come in to see me playing all the time. And I moved back to New York for almost a year and I got called, he was doing a television show and I got called — he quit the show by the way, he quit the show. He had some kind of thing with Westinghouse, boom he quit. And they booked this young kid in, Regis Philbin. That he was going to start the next week. And the people who produced "The Steve Allen Show" liked when I appeared as a guest with Steve. They liked my dumb sense of humor and what I did, and they knew I can play, and they didn't care if I knew how to conduct or anything, they called me and asked me if I would audition, not playing, I'd be the second banana, you know, as a band leader, with what kind of rapport I'd have with Regis. And two other guys were Barney, I mean Bobby Troup — I didn't know this — and Ray Anthony, both up for the job. But they liked what I had to say you know. And then they wanted to give me a nine piece band. They said — wait, you got the job, a nine piece band, that's what Steve had. I said no, I don't want the job with nine pieces. First of all we were on at night opposite Les Crane at that time who had Elliott Lawrence and sixteen pieces, and Johnny Carson, who had Doc Severinsen. I said if we have nine pieces are we going to try to sound like sixteen? I said either give me sixteen or give me a sextet. And we weren't in competition with anybody. They said, "Can you make it work with six?" I said, "I'll make it work, no problem." And so the Regis Philbin Show, and by the way he's one of the nicest people living. I taped one of these shows about a month ago which will be shown sometime in January. I'm not sure when this is going to be shown, but sometime in January it will be shown. And we got along great. In fact, I was the second banana, Regis wasn't into jazz at all. He really didn't know much about jazz, and we'd have Count — and they weren't fair to Regis, really. Because all the guests that were booked for the first ten weeks probably were Steve Allen's guests that were booked a long time ago. And Regis, that's not his bag. Jazz people are not his bag. We'd have Sarah Vaughan, Count Basie, we had all the heavyweight players. And we had Count Basie on. I remember when we had Count Basie. Count Basie is the worst interview in the world. He could yes and no you to death. You know if you were sitting here with me and you asked me a question and I'd say, "yes" "no." You'd have a nervous breakdown after a while. So Regis would ask him

a question, "yes," "no," he asked him. Finally I said, "Regis, I want to ask Basie a question." He said, "Go ahead, Terry." I went down and said, "Basie, when we played in Detroit that time, remember that scene with Pee Wee Marquette? Tell Regis." He had to tell the story now. So every time we had a jazz musician — Stan Getz, every time he interviewed, I had to be down there with him. He was really great. That wasn't his bag. I used to put him on all the time. He always thought that we were putting him on because we were jazz players. But we really loved him. He loved the band and he always praised the band.

MR: Well Steve Allen was —

TG: Oh let me get back to that, because you asked me how I got with Steve. Then Steve asked me if I would conduct for him. And I had another show coming up. By that time I was ready to sit down and settle down. No first he asked me actually if I would go to Las Vegas with him. Because I taught Steve how to play vibes, and we used to close out the show playing the vibes. I taught him how to do that. When he'd come in the club we'd do that. So he thought it'd be good in the show. I would play a song I had written up on "I Got Rhythm," an arrangement. I played piano with him then I'd play a ballad and show all the technique and everything, and I taught him "Tall Hands" so whatever I did he did just as well. And people thought he was just as good as I was. So we went to Vegas and we closed with that. You know we'd close every show. Then he asked me if I'd like to conduct a television show for him. And so at that time the people who I worked with on Regis Philbin show, a guy called Bill Carruthers, became a big producer/director with Chuck Barris, and they asked me if I would conduct the band for a show called "Operation Entertainment." And I already was committed. So I did that. And then when I got done with that Steve asked me if I would conduct for him, so I went with Steve and stayed with him for fifteen, sixteen years. We played a lot of night clubs all over the country and television. And he was fun to be with, especially in night clubs, because he's not like a comedian who tells jokes. If the chandelier fell down, ten more minutes to his act. He looks at anything that goes wrong. In fact when we used to rehearse the band in the afternoon, if a guy came in wearing a weird cap and whatever he was wearing weird, I'd have him wear that cap. I'd have them, whatever weird way they would look, he'd love that. Anything. He'd turn around and look at the band and he'd break up. And he'd work to the band sometimes. He'd turn around and work to the band. We got along real great.

MR: You did a lot of things, for sure.

TG: Yup. It was a big shock for me when he went.

MR: Yeah. It's a big loss. I wanted to ask you about — I have some little things that I dug up. Something about you calling Dorsey a bad name or something? What was that about?

TG: No, I didn't call Dorsey a bad name ever. He called me a bad name.

MR: Oh, okay. Oh Dorsey calling you a bad name. That's what it was.

TG: But it wasn't really, I mean he called everybody — I mean what happened actually, now this was 1947. If I worked three days a year I was doing well. I was an unknown playing on 52nd Street once in a while, learning, trying to learn bebop like Charlie Parker. And I get a call from Tommy Dorsey's office, would I join the Tommy Dorsey band. $165 a week. Now I was making $165 every two years. And so he would fly me out there, you know, everything first class. And my mother wouldn't let me fly. And you've got to listen to your mother in those days. But he actually got me a compartment on a train. Five days I was in a compartment going nuts. You know you've got all that energy, I was only about 22, 23. I got out to California, they picked me up at the railroad station and boosted me out right to the Casino Ballroom in Santa Monica, and they set up the vibes, I set them up, and I played one tune before the intermission. And it felt terrible. I mean I was trying to learn bebop and he was playing songs, all these old things. It had nothing to do with what I was trying to do. But I did get to meet Louis Bellson who I didn't know, and Charlie Shavers, and Ziggy Elman. And now so at intermission — I just got there now, you've got to remember, about 15 minutes — I went over to the manager, I said, "Mr. Jagel, I don't know how to tell you this but I've got to give you my notice." He says, "Wait a minute, you just got here. What happened?" I tried to explain Dizzy Gillespie, I said I'm trying to learn this. Now when you quit a band, you've got to pay your own way home. If you get fired the band leader has to pay your way home. Now in those days nobody ever quit Tommy Dorsey or Benny Goodman. They fired you. Glenn Miller. If you wanted to stay you could stay with those bands for the rest of your life, because it was the best music and the best jobs. Anyhow, Tommy — can I use some of these words on the air?

MR: Sure.

TG: It's really not that dirty. I'm standing there talking to Louis Bellson, Charlie Shavers, and I get a tap on the shoulder. Now I used to box by the way. And if somebody tapped me, if that was the wrong tap I would have turned around and hit him, without even knowing who it was. I turned around ready to protect myself, and Tommy was about six foot two, six foot three, but he looked about nine foot tall. Because he looked down at me with hatred and he says, "You little shithead. You just quit my band?" And I tried to say, "Mr. Dorsey, Charlie Parker—" "I don't give a shit about that" he says, "nobody quits my band. You're fired." I said, "well if you fire me, you've got to pay my way home." He says, "No, you quit." So that's why, but he wouldn't let me go home. I sat there two weeks and he never let me play. The only time I ever played is he was doing a moving

picture and he needed the last set and Ziggy Elman would take over the band, and he let me play a little bit. Otherwise I sat there and turned pages.

MR: You sat there for two weeks. Jeez.

TG: And you know what is wild? How I got home, Louis Bellson was on the same picture with Benny Goodman and Tommy Dorsey. I think it was with Danny Kaye, the picture they did years ago. "The Red Nichols Story" maybe. The Five Pennies

MR: Oh yeah, could be.

TG: They were on I think, and Louis wanted Benny to hear me play. So Louis Bellson and a guy called Bill Miller, who was Frank Sinatra's piano player, he was playing piano with Tommy then, and I forget the bass player. We stayed over after the show, the job was over, and we made a tape for Benny to hear me play. He wanted Benny to hear me play. Now Benny — now Tommy would get no sleep. And Benny loved to play all the time. So while they say "cut," you know, whatever scene they're shooting, he stopped playing. The moment he stopped playing Lionel would jump in because you can't stop Lionel at all. And Tommy says, "Come on, Benny, stop that bullshit" he says, "I haven't slept at all." So Benny put the clarinet down. Three and a half minutes later he'd forget completely and start playing again. And Tommy'd say, "God damn that —" and Lionel would jump in. "That God damn Benny," he said "I told you put that clarinet away." Maybe this time he waited around four minutes. And Tommy went over and hit him. He had knocked him down. Now so the record never got to Benny Goodman. But Louis played it for Lionel Hampton. So Lionel called me. And he says, "hey Gates" he says, "Louis gave me the record, you've got to play in my band," he says, "he tells me you play drums also." He says, "you play drums in my band and I'll give you 12 solos — I'll bill you ma-ma-ma protégé, hey Gates." So I figured great. Then later on his wife called. Now he had nothing to worry about because even though I was a kid, Lionel Hampton would wipe anybody out — he would jump over four tom-toms to hit an A flat, you know. He's in show business. Lionel, you can't cap him. It came down to being like four solos, after we talked, and then no solos. They wanted me to just play drums. And I didn't want to do that. So they paid my way home. So that's how I got back.

MR: I'll be darned. Well you really knew your mind, what you wanted to do.

TG: I always wanted — it was something I wanted to learn. I almost had a nervous breakdown the first time I heard Charlie Parker and Dizzy Gillespie. It was something so new to me, something I was looking for all my life. Because I had all this technique and didn't know what to do with it. And my idols were Roy Eldridge and Lester Young. They played so pretty and simple. And I had all this technique. So I gave up playing vibes and playing drums. When I heard Bird and Diz I said what is that? Because they played all these technique things, and I was in the Army at that time. And I listened for fifteen— I

went back and played four million notes, maybe three were right. Maybe. But I knew the timing. I got the timing down. That was my whole life. Music has always been my whole life. So, Monk, seriously, I don't even buy anything. I'm 76 years old now, with the body of a man 75, so, and the brain of a 19 year old idiot. If I didn't like music — I am not a millionaire, but I'm okay. I don't have to go anywhere anymore. I lucked out with land and all that. But the point I'm getting at is if I was in a band that didn't have fun coming out and playing, I wouldn't come out. I love sitting at home. By the way, whatever I do I do hard. I get on stage and I play hard. If I sit at home, I do nothing hard. I can do it better than anybody. I can be a couch potato better than anybody living. The hardest part about going out, not as much as I used to, I only go out about four times a month maybe. You've got to practice every day. And it's hard at my age to really get yourself up there and practice. Like George Foreman, 50 years old, if he has to have a fight, you think he wants to run ten miles? No way. He doesn't want to run around half a block. But to keep in shape and be capable of doing what I'm capable of doing, I've got to practice.

MR: When you went out to Los Angeles. What was the scene between black and white musicians like at that point?

TG: You know it's a weird thing. Let me first use a line that Dick Cavett said, "I'd never look" — before I say this Dick Cavett once had Lester Maddox on his show. You know Lester Maddox who was a mayor in Alabama?

MR: Yes.

TG: He was a bigot. An out and out bigot. He had him on the show and Lester was saying to Dick Cavett he says, "Wait a minute" he says, "I'm not prejudiced at all, not at all, I don't see any difference between black and white." So Dick says, "You'd better buy a pair of glasses because there's a big difference between black and white." I never looked at it as color. I wanted the best musicians in my band. Because where I lived on the east coast, I went out with the quartet I had was Terry Pollard for four years, I had the same musicians most of the time. I had two — and Terry Pollard was a girl, a young black girl. Going on the road, they wanted to kill me, they thought it was my wife. I never looked at it that way. I just got the best players I could get. I want the best players. I'm only as good as what's behind me. The race scene, let's face it, it was bad all over. Even the music. It was bad not for the — amongst the musicians, but the audience — not even the audience. They came to see you, once you got off the stage and walked on the street it was probably bad. Oh yeah. Of course I traveled with a whole black show. The biggest show I'd ever been in with my life, and I got to see how bad it was. It was called the Birdland All-Stars of 1957. Headliners — listen to this show, you won't believe this one show — Billy Eckstine, in his heyday, and he had a trio with, I forget the three guys, that famous guy, oh Bobby Tucker on piano, and whoever he had playing bass and drums. Sarah Vaughan.

And she had Jimmy Jones playing piano, Roy Haynes playing and Richard Davis. So that's that trio. Count Basie band with Joe Williams. Now this is one show. Count Basie and Joe Williams. Phineas Newborn's trio. Bud Powell's trio. Lester Young's trio. Zoot Sims, Chet Baker's group and Jeri Southern. That was one show. But then unfortunately Chet Baker's band, they all got busted. After we were out about three days Jeri Southern got fired because she was half drunk all the time and soon had other commitments. So I was the only white person on the whole show. And I saw how bad it was for black people, not only with white people down south but the black people weren't good to the guys. They'd rip them off at the hotels because you couldn't get them to stay anywhere, they'd rip off the black guys just like a white guy would, you know. It was bad. But amongst us, we had a lot of fun. I mean but it was great, I learned a whole new experience because everybody's got their own culture. I love ethnic humor. I love sick humor. Anything dumb and sick, I could never, you can use those words today, calling each other what black people called you. In those days you could if you were in the thing. For some reason with young people it's more offensive. But amongst the guys it's something else.

MR: Did you get to rub elbows much with Joe Williams?

TG: One of my real — I knew Joe Williams before the Basie band, because when I was with Woody Herman's band, we had a baseball team. You know we had a team. And we used to play. Joe was with Red Saunders in Chicago and we used to play them in baseball.

MR: Wow, that far back.

TG: Yeah I knew Joe from those days. And Joe and I were really close on the trips. I loved him. We really got along great.

MR: Well this has really just been a fascinating—

TG: Great.

MR: —hour of talking.

TG: I'm ready to faint, but it's okay.

MR: You fit a lot in, and I'm very appreciative of your time.

TG: Well I'm glad it worked out for you.

MR: What's in the future for you? Any exciting projects coming up?

TG: Well just concerts and festivals and college things. That's all I want to do. My best job actually is a college thing because first of all Yamaha sponsors me, you know, the college can only afford to pay me two dollars, they pay the rest. I made a deal with Yamaha to use their instrument. They supply me with instruments everywhere I go. I put a price on my clinic, like I said, on my job. And I use the Dream Band music more than anything. I send out about eight charts, everybody wants to play it. And the band leader rehearses them all a week, or two weeks, and then I get there Friday night, work with them

Saturday afternoon and do a clinic even though they know the charts, just a little edges I want. I don't try to step on the band leader and make him look like he doesn't know what he's doing. Because he's already there, and I'd have to spend like another week to get it like I wanted. But it's so good, the music is so good, sixty percent of it is so good that sixty percent will sound good, no matter if they make mistakes. It's there. And I do a clinic and I play the concert at night and go home the next day. I like those jobs. I do that twice, three times a month. And then I work as much as I can with Buddy DeFranco. That's my favorite of all. We've been playing together for 25 years as co-leaders — I mean not 25 years, since 1981, which is what 22 years or 21? We've been playing together as co-leaders and we have never come close to having an argument. Ever. And Buddy's funny. He came to my clinic today. And he says this all the time, I tell the audience we've never had a fight in 21 years, never. He says, "The reason why, I don't know what he's saying. He talks so fast I don't know what he's saying to me."

MR: Good one. All right. Well listen, I hope you have a safe trip home. Best of luck with your upcoming things, and I really appreciate your time.

TG: Is there any way I'm getting a copy of this?

MR: Absolutely.

TG: You have my address at home I take it?

MR: I do. I will send you a copy.

TG: I'd like to hear some of these stupid things that I say on these interviews.

MR: All right.

TG: I'll wanted to tell you this one thing, [inaudible] on the air, about the first question you asked me and then you said we'll go somewhere else?

MR: Oh.

TG: Well we had Jonathan Winters on the show one time, and you know Jonathan, right? Jonathan's really out there. And the premise of this whole thing was, it was probably in July and we were doing a Christmas show. And the premise was that Jonathan had a clay piggy bank that he was returning. Steve Allen was behind the counter. And Steve came over the counter and he was next in line. And he said, "Yes sir." And he said, "What's wrong with that?" And all of a sudden Jonathan went — this is a Christmas show — went to Japan. All of a sudden he's talking about some far out thing. He went somewhere else. Completely had nothing to do with — and Steve went right with him, wherever he went, he was there. He went to Yugoslavia, whatever he thought up. For about 20 minutes Steve went with him everywhere he went with him until the cue came up from the producer, a Christmas show. So you've got to go back there. So he went back there. But why are you returning the pig? And we got our Christmas show in. So what they did out of that 20 minutes, they took eight minutes out of each — he went to Japan, Yugoslavia,

Germany, wherever he went, they took eight minutes of what he was talking about and put it in six different shows. And all brilliant. All eight minutes of brilliance. Because Jonathan Winters is a monster mind. He's out there, completely out there.

MR: And I guess if you had to pick somebody to hang out with him like that.

TG: And Steve's a great straight man. He doesn't care to get the laugh, he just laughs at you. He cackles through everything you're saying. And Jonathan, I'm telling you, the first thing when he said, "Why are you returning this pig," his first answer had nothing to do with the show. Had nothing to do with Christmas, nothing to do with a pig, it had to do with his mother-in-law, back in Chicago, wherever he went.

MR: Great. Is that stuff still on tape you think? Is it gettable? Can you watch those things now?

TG: I have some at home that Steve gave me of some of the shows that he's done. And they're priceless. One time he wrote an eleven minute bit, a hip version of "The Taming of the Shrew" with hip words, with every word ending with th. [speaks in lisp]. It was so dumb. You fell on the floor, you just couldn't go through it. And he was a great writer, you know that?

MR: Hold on for one second. We're wired here.